

at least 70%," says Mariwala, without a trace of conceit.

Today, Marico gets over 27% of its business from international markets, which include Bangladesh, Egypt, Malaysia, Myanmar, South Africa and Vietnam.

"Going overseas is a key part of our growth story. We are the largest Indian company in Bangladesh and learnt quickly that having a presence outside is a different ballgame," Mariwala says.

Mukherjea calls Mariwala a "calculated risk taker," who knows when to pull back.

"For example, he was amongst the first FMCG promoters to enter other Asian countries. He was also amongst the first to pull back on investments in these overseas markets when he realised that the RoCE on domestic investments was much higher." RoCE is short for Return on Capital Employed, a ratio used as a measure of a company's profitability and capital efficiency.

Mariwala is big on consumer insights and constantly looks for them, even if a business move fails to pay off.

An example is Saffola's venture into baked snacks where the focus on health took precedence over taste. "That will not work in foods, especially the impulse (buying) category," he says. The launch of Saffola oats and the aftermath was not easy for the brand to traverse. "The consumer insight was the desire for a savoury breakfast taste and we went overboard on that with variants for each state. Today, it (oats business) is a ₹400 crore brand with an 80% market share," Mariwala says.

LEGACY

Once he stepped down as Managing Director in 2014 in favour of Saugata Gupta, who had joined the company 10 years earlier, he adopted what he calls a "hands-off but mind-on" approach towards the company.

According to Kripalu, Mariwala has the ability to be dispassionate towards business, citing the case of leadership transition. "He would keenly listen to board members before any decision was made apart from making the effort to connect with them outside of board meetings for their advice. Harsh also had the vision and sense of purpose to make Marico one of the best board-managed companies by bringing in the famed Ram Charan to be a board mentor," Kripalu adds.

The legacy that Marico must leave behind is critical to Mariwala. Marico Innovation Foundation, a philan-

thropic institution, was started 22 years ago when there was no concept of mandatory Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) spending. It started in Kerala to help improve the productivity of coconut growers. "Marico as an organisation stands for all stakeholders and that includes employees, promoters and society," Mariwala says.

Equally important is Ascent, an initiative to identify high-potential, growth-stage entrepreneurs in which they can learn from one another. "Today, there are 1,100 of them with a turnover of ₹1.2 lakh crore providing employment to 3.2 lakh people," the Marico founder says.

Then, there is Marico Health Initiative, which works with 50 organisations in the field of mental health.

Mariwala speaks of his strong belief in the concept of



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perpetuity, or permanence. "FMCG is a relatively defensive sector and disruptions are manageable if you create strong brands. The risk of something like technology is much lower and I believe organisations must have (sense of) perpetuity."

Mariwala's passion for consumer brands remains unabated if only because of familiarity with the business. "My weakness is that I cannot deal with bureaucrats and feel more comfortable with retailers and distributors. I would have never succeeded in a B2B business," he says. **BT**

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